Once again I stood at the first place on the victory stand, with Khaliq on the second and a Japanese athlete at the third place. Professor G.D. Sondhi, a member of the Indian Olympic Committee, placed the gold medal around my neck. I felt like reminding Khaliq about ‘Tom, Dick and Harry’, but that was not my style.

With this victory I had entered the select group of Asia’s top athletes. My fame had spread quickly, with headlines proclaiming: *MILKHA RUNS 200 METRES IN RECORD TIME* . I returned to my room and once again found scores of congratulatory messages, letters and telegrams waiting for me. As I looked at them, I thought about how far I had travelled from my obscure little village in Pakistan, and a sense of loss suddenly came upon me as vivid images from my life flashed through my mind— my father’s and brothers’ deaths, my mother’s anguished cries from inside the burning gurudwara, the horrors of Partition, bloodshed and slaughter, the train to Delhi, despair, suffering, poverty, rejection, struggles, the days of crime on the streets, ten days in jail, a lucky break in the army, life in the barracks, my chance encounter with running, my relentless training schedule, my sacrifices, my goal, lady luck smiling on me, fame and recognition, hero-worship by the loving masses… My dreams had become reality… The rush of emotions overwhelmed me and I put my head down and sobbed like a child. The storms had steeled me, but the glories of the present had rocked me back into dark visions of the past. But then the stream of life moves on.

Parduman Singh, who had won the gold in shot-put and silver in discus, returned to the room in good humour. Listening to him speak and laughing at his jokes was like a tonic and I began to feel more cheerful again. As we talked, the phone kept ringing and there were frequent knocks at the door as my fellow athletes, including some Pakistani athletes from Punjab, came in to congratulate me. This spirit of camaraderie, particularly from the Pakistanis, dispelled some of the rancour of our bloodstained past.

That night, we attended the emperor’s banquet at the Imperial Palace and I was formally introduced to His Highness, who graciously said, through an interpreter, ‘We were pleased to watch your run. If you continue your efforts you will become the world’s number one champion.’ I humbly thanked him for his kind words of encouragement and diffidently replied, saying that my success was due to the love and encouragement extended to me by the people of Japan.